Upside Down Kingdom 2

Week 3 — 10/13/26

Matthew 5:21–26

Beatitudes 5:3–12	3 Hope Images 5:13–16	**Antitheses 5:17–48**	Righteous Practices 6:1–20	Parallel Discourses 6:21–7:12	3 Warning Images 7:13–27

REVIEW OF LAST WEEK

- Jesus reveals the full intention of God's will in the Torah and embodies it in his life and teaching.
- Torah's authority is tied to created the world under God's word; Jesus's resurrection is the introduction of a completely new reality.
- Jesus is claiming that there is a righteousness that can exceed that of people who seemed devoted to doing what God commanded.

PASSAGE OF THE WEEK (NET)

a
b
a'
b
a''
b'
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b''
a
b
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b'
c

21 You have heard that it was said to an older generation, 'Do not murder,' and 'whoever murders
will be subjected to judgment.'

22 But I say to you that anyone who is angry with a brother
will be subjected to judgment.
And whoever insults a brother
will be brought before the council,
and whoever says 'Fool'
will be sent to fiery hell.

23 So then, if you bring your gift to the altar
and there you remember that your brother has something against you,
24 leave your gift there in front of the altar.
First go and be reconciled to your brother
and then come and present your gift.

25 Reach agreement quickly with your accuser while on the way to court,
or he may hand you over to the judge,
and the judge hand you over to the warden,
and you will be thrown into prison.

26 I tell you the truth, you will never get out of there
until you have paid the last penny!

INDIVIDUALS' TRANSLATIONS

Tim Mackie

21 You have heard that **it was said** to the ancients, "You shall not commit murder," and "Whoever commits murder will be guilty by the court." **22** **And I say** to you, that everyone who is angry with his brother will be guilty by the court; and whoever says to his brother, "You good-for-nothing," will be guilty by the Sanhedrin; and whoever says, "You fool," will be guilty for the gehenna of fire. **23** Therefore if you are presenting your offering at the altar, and there remember that your brother has something against you, **24** leave your offering there before the altar and go, first be reconciled to your brother, and then come and present your offering. **25** Settle matters in a friendly way with your legal opponent, while you are with him on the way, so that your opponent doesn't hand you over to the court-judge, and the court-judge to the officer, so you're thrown into prison. **26** Truly I say to you, you will not come out of there until you have paid up the last coin.

COMMENTARY QUOTES

Never in the Mosaic covenant (or at any other time) did God ignore or disregard the ethical state or inner disposition of the person. The point of the Ten Commandments was never "just do these things outwardly and don't worry about your hearts." Quite the opposite. The message of the prophets is largely one of calling God's people to pursue righteousness and do it from pure, whole hearts. Sometimes God's people are called to repentance and turning away from outward physical acts—sins of omission and commission—but the issue of the heart or the inner person is always present even there...[Jesus] is pulling back the veil on outward ethics and reminding God's people—especially the "extra-super-holy" ones—that true righteousness cannot be construed as mere outward obedience. It must be understood as *wholeness* (5:48). He is not changing the ethics of the old-covenant commands; he is revealing them as any good prophet does. Yet, as has also been noted, Jesus's role is *more* than prophetic; it is also eschatologically consummating. He did come to *fulfill* the law, not just to reiterate.

— Jonathan Pennington, *The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing, p.X*

Finally, and in contrast to later Christian interpretation...Jesus does not make allowance for justified anger, for "holy hate" (such as hate of demons or evil thoughts), or for the wrath of the state. As it stands, Jesus' prohibition of anger is unqualified (contrast Eph 4.26). This fact would seem to take Jesus one step beyond the wisdom tradition and may well have struck his contemporaries as novel.

— W.D. Davies & Dale Allison, *The Gospel According to Saint Matthew, vol. 1, p.521*

It is a mistake to treat these stipulations casuistically and thus fall into a new and harsh nomism. While they are meant to be taken seriously,...they...function more as exhortations to a life that perfectly reflects the reality of the kingdom. This teaching is not necessarily incompatible with the display of righteous anger by Jesus in Mark 3:5 (cf. Eph 4:26) or his calling the Pharisees "Fools" in 23:17 (where Matthew uses the same word as here).

— Donald A. Hagner, *Matthew 1–13, p.118*

OLD TESTAMENT Genesis 4:2–12 (NASB)

[Relevance: a story about murder and anger: a man upset with his brother while at the altar affecting his relationship with God]

> **2** Now Abel was a keeper of flocks, but Cain was a cultivator of the ground. **3** So it came about in the course of time that Cain brought an offering to the Lord from the fruit of the ground. **4** Abel, on his part also brought an offering, from the firstborn of his flock and from their fat portions. And the Lord had regard for Abel and his offering; **5** but for Cain and his offering He had no regard. So Cain became very angry and his face was gloomy. **6** Then the Lord said to Cain, "Why are you angry? And why is your face gloomy? **7** If you do well, will your face not be cheerful? And if you do not do well, sin is lurking at the door; and its desire is for you, but you must master it." **8** Cain talked to his brother Abel; and it happened that when they were in the field Cain rose up against his brother Abel and killed him.
>
> **9** Then the Lord said to Cain, "Where is Abel your brother?" And he said, "I do not know. Am I my brother's keeper?" **10** Then He said, "What have you done? The voice of your brother's blood is crying out to Me from the ground. **11** Now you are cursed from the ground, which has opened its mouth to receive your brother's blood from your hand. **12** When you cultivate the ground, it will no longer yield its strength to you; you will be a wanderer and a drifter on the earth."

CHALLENGING QUESTIONS

1. (v. 22) Why does Jesus's authority rest on an appeal to nothing else but simply what he himself says? (Pennington, p.181 n.29)
2. (v. 23) Has my brother done wrong against me? Or does he have something against me because of the wrong I have done to him?
3. (v. 23–24) Why does it matter that I reconcile first? What changes? Can't I reconcile with my brother afterwards? What is actually happening metaphysically? (cf. 1 Pet. 3:7, lest my prayers be hindered...?)
4. (v. 25) Why does Jesus suddenly turn to pragmatic/utilitarian debt advice? Is it a parable? Does 18:21–35 provide enough resolution?
5. Why increase punishments (court, court, Sanhedrin council, hellfire) while decreasing severity (murder, anger, deep insult, passing insult)?

JOURNAL NOTES

21 You have heard that it was said to those of old, 'You shall not murder; and whoever murders will be liable to judgment.' **22** But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment; whoever insults his brother will be liable to the council; and whoever says, 'You fool!' will be liable to the hell of fire. **23** So if you are offering your gift at the altar and there remember that your brother has something against you, **24** leave your gift there before the altar and go. First be reconciled to your brother, and then come and offer your gift. **25** Come to terms quickly with your accuser while you are going with him to court, lest your accuser hand you over to the judge, and the judge to the guard, and you be put in prison. **26** Truly, I say to you, you will never get out until you have paid the last penny. (ESV)